Meeting Notes

Project Civic-Signal

Team Meeting Tuesday 9/29 (7:00-8:30pm)
Video call link: https://meet.google.com/odi-xddv-kez
Or dial: (US) +1 254-218-5862 PIN: 199 901 399#
More phone numbers: https://tel.meet/odi-xddv-kez?pin=2308079664797

Week of 9/21

Shared google draw
https://drive.google.com/file/d/1E-m7HzjQ4FNLUcSI5r0AJqMWDjDz8BKN/view?usp=sharing

- Energy Bill AI tool
  - Walk through project plan/ goals/ potential user questions
  - What else do we need to start building out this tool?
- Tasks to be completed
  - Does anyone want to take the lead on creating a product name, tag line, and logo?
    - Aim to have completed by Oct. 2nd (even a first draft version) ~9 days from Today, 9/23
  - Ideas for product name?
    - Mannan: Bill Hero, Grid Hero, Utility Hero, WattsUp, Bill Neighbor, Over the Fence
    -
- Need to define questions and decision trees to answer questions
  - The rates for electricity have increased making it hard to make ends meet, what can I do?
    -
    - What assistance programs do I qualify for?
      - What is the Percentage of Income Payment Program?
        - Pay your reduced bill in full and on time each month
        - Each month, 1/12 of your old balance is forgiven
        - After 12 months of on-time payments, your past-due balance is gone
      - Do I qualify for the Percentage of Income Payment Program?
        - Are you a Dominion Energy or APCo/AEP customer?
        - What is your household income?
        - Do you have an active electrical account?
        - Do you have proof of income for the past 30 days?
        - Do you have a current electric bill?
        - Do you have SSN for all members of your household?
- Do we want this tool to be public?

    - Will require funding to keep it running at a better quality than it would running off of free AI systems
    - Database hosed in the cloud but will be stored on Mannan's accounts
- Next steps
    - Everyone contribute to questions/decision trees
        - Hyperlink answers to questions (you don't need to link every question if they all come from the same website)
    - Need product name, tag line, and logo

Upskilling Cycle Check-in

- Important Dates
    - Oct. 11th: Summit presentation slides due at midnight ~ 9 days from the 10/2 first draft due date
    - Oct. 12th: Summit dry run
    - Oct. 13th: Summit at MLK library - teams present projects and learning to audience
        - Presentations start at 5:30 - need to use a Google Slide
- Final Presentation & Deliverables
    - MVP prototype is whatever you decide to build (most end up being an app but that's not a requirement)
    - Each group will have ~5 mins to present their project, which should include:
        - Problem - Solution Demo (prerecorded) - What you Learned - What tools you used - Team Members
        - 5ish slides
            - Need 1 person to be presenter
- Next Steps
    - Product name, tag line, logo (**AIM FOR OCT 2nd!)**
        - The Labs Marketing/Communication team will start asking for this soon
    - Product splash page (screenshot of what the first page of the product might look like)
        - Marketing team will also likely start asking for this soon as well
    - QR code that takes you to the product splash page

Team Meeting Wednesday 9/23 (7:00-8:30pm)

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Team members emails

- maggie.m.ward@gmail.com

- morgenstern.msu@gmail.com
- jaschuck19@gmail.com
- hello@mannan.is

Persona 1- Maggie- needs help, shame, unaware, speaks to computer

Persona 2- Mannan- needs help, shame, needs permission, speaks to computer, not speaking to friends, tackling the follow through component of getting materials together to figure out how to apply to things

Persona 3- Blue- needs help, afraid to ask for help, speaks to friends, school, community members, rely on family to help one another

Persona 4- Nasim- 62, needs help, shame, guilt asking for help from anyone, would ask utilities, not government, doesn't know who to talk to and would rely on family members to help. Follow through is not an issue, will trust others when information comes through trusted source

Persona 5: Pastor/Social worker: know people need help, know how to nudge them to get support, not necessarily aware of all the government programs or how individual people qualify, way too many cases

Parent coordinators/community members:

Chat bot:
- Hi- chat bot starts conversation
- Do you need help paying your bills?
    - Yes
    - OK- send image of the bot

Action Items (Roles)
RE: Developing tool that efficiently provides an individual or trusted advisor the information and contacts they need to address issues with electricity (& water?) in Fairfax County (may narrow to specific neighborhood if easier to develop for) - issues such as increase in rates, help with bills, etc.
- Maggie: AI coding - start drafting UI
- Mannan: Work with maggie to figure out backend
- Julie: Research, questions and sources
- Nicole: Research, questions and sources

Meeting Schedule:
- Next Monday 9/21- at the Upskilling

- Next Tuesday 9/22, 7pm, project team online
- Tuesday evenings, project team check ins

9/15 Meeting Notes

Research
- You can have amazing tools, but people aren't going to use them.
-

Hypothesis
- **Can we build tools for the trusted advisor?**
    - Minister
    - Apartment manager
    - School official
    - Feasibility of getting things out and making things available to people
- Narrowing it down
    - Community groups- focusing on 1-2 specific
    - Focus on the narrowing of the tool scope?
    - Integrating something with Whatsapp?
        - Workforce access and labor laws

Problem
- People don't know enough about government programming but everyone needs help with utility bills.
- Utility bills are out of control, community members need help understanding their bills and where they can get support

Solution
- AI conversational tool (possibly integrated with WhatsApp) for users to ask questions about their electric bills

Role Assignment
- Maggie: AI coding - start drafting UI
- Mannan: Work with maggie to figure out backend
- Julie: Research, questions and sources
- Nicole: Research, questions and sources

Meeting Schedule:
- Next Monday- at the Upskilling
- Next Tuesday online

1. "Symptom-to-System" Conversational AI Tools

Instead of asking citizens *"Which department do you need to reach?"* or *"What service are you looking for?"*, tools focus purely on everyday human symptoms.

- **How it Works:** An AI interface (via WhatsApp, voice notes, or SMS) prompts users to describe what is stressing them out in plain language—without using any civic vocabulary.
- **The Interaction:**
    - **User:** *"My boss cut my hours because I asked why my paycheck was short, and now I can't pay my electric bill."*
    - **AI Re-frame:** *"This is not just a personal disagreement with your employer. Under labor laws, your boss cannot legally punish you for asking about missing pay (Retaliation). Also, there is an emergency utility grant program specifically designed to stop electric shutoffs while wage claims are investigated."*
- **The Shift:** It bridges the gap between *"I'm having a bad week"* and *"My rights are being infringed, and there is a public agency built to intervene."*
-
-
- Electric bills as it pertains to Fairfax- tool that is integrated with whatsapp- I live….my electricity bill jumped, what do I need to do?

Week of 9/8

Meeting on Thursday September 10th at 8:30pm - Mannan, Julie, Maggie

Meet the Pods Notes

- Who is our target audience? Use this week to narrow in on our target audience, should have one or two primary audiences we are first building this tool for.
-

Hypothesis Framework: I believe {person} has {problem} because {reason}. I will challenge this if {what evidence or counter you would need to see}

1: I believe first generation 30-35 year old immigrants experience the problem of feeling that their needs don't matter and they need someone else's approval to solve them. Grew up being told they are visitors, be grateful, stay quiet. Challenge if I could hear those who don't experience this because others are requesting without seeking approval or permission.

2: People don't engage because they don't know what they could ask for

Immigrants- population advocacy groups
Churches might be a way to access these populations

Do we narrow to services?
Tool that surfaces what people want that gets at the opinion and emails the appropriate division

Customer outreach is coming up next - drafted a cold email and reaching out to target demographic without biasing the data

3: People in fairfax have the issue that people don't know how to find the right information on the website for a problem they have because the website has so much and it sucks. I will challenge this if I hear that people don't even go to the website.

4. People don't care enough to find the right information on the website to find a problem they have.

> Are we trying to get people to care?

5. People have the issues related to zoning and permits that they are going to people they know for information and advice instead of the local government and still don't know how to do it despite getting it explained multileple

I need these things from my local government

Questions we would want to ask:

- Residential property changes and information about county allowances
    - Residents for property related questions
    - Research on 2-3 core zoning things and solving those well
        - Downloading forms
        - Talking to neighbors
        - Hearing
        - Inviting to hearing
        - Navigating what the chicken coop needs to look like
        - Waht about the fence
- Neighborhood repairs
-

How do they find out the population needs?

Officials don't hear from their constituents because they don't have a good system for getting information?

- Which do you hear frmo frequently and which do you not?

Homeowners don't know how to access government information or don't trust people, so they give up on projects

Immigrants don't feel like their needs matter, so they stay silent and never reach out for help.

National research on community's connectivity to their local government

- The National Civic League survey found that while many Americans felt left out of local decision-making and disconnected from their neighbors they remained eager for better ways to participate.
    - Less than 9% of people overall say they receive public information on time, with nearly half of urban residents reporting that information is at least “sometimes timely”.
    - However more than a third of suburban residents said that information usually arrives late and reported the highest share of “too late” responses.
    - When it comes to taking part in local decision-making, nearly half cited time as the biggest barrier.
- ACCESS NYC: Mobile-friendly screener that matches users eligibility across 80 benefit programs, available in 11 languages, with human-translated program guides covering how to apply, what documents you need, and application channels.
- Southeast Iowa Resource Finder (SIRF): Electronic tool designed to streamline access to local service providers and resource the learning cost for individuals seeking assistance.
    - Minimizes complicated steps by helping users more quickly find the correct programs and avoid wasting time applying for the services they don’t qualify for or missing necessary documentation

Fairfax County’s own research points to residents needing better connection to resources as a growing challenge

- Community Health Improvement Plan (CHIP) - The county found that despite Fairfax being a resource-rich community, navigating complex systems and processes required to access assistance presents significant challenges, becoming a barrier for many.
    - Community members reported difficulty keeping track of the vast and fragmented health information available
- Fairfax County deployed ‘Ask Fairfax’ AI Chatbot last month
    - Answers questions in a conversational format, pulling answers from the county website
    - Multilingual
- Fairfax County doesn’t appear to have a true 311
    - Contact page directs people to a general information line, with more specific questions getting routed to a list of separate numbers

Immigrant Community’s Access to Government

- In 2022 VA released a ‘Barriers to Integration of Virginia’s Immigrants’ report - there’s a section about Overcoming a Trust Deficit and Uncertain Legal Status as a Barrier to Civic Integration
    - Lack of trust means that information needs to move outside government press releases and leverage the power of one-to-one interactions through social media and WhatApp
    - Uncertainty and fear mean that many immigrants avoid social and community events, leaving their voices unheard.

- In 2021 Fairfax announced they would be creating an Immigrant Community Liaison, a new position that would work to build bridges with local immigrant communities
    - Position was supposed to work with community, stakeholder groups, nonprofits, and interfaith organization to create strong networks that facilitate coordination and the connection of Fairfax County's immigrant community to the information, resources, and services that will support their success

Potential Needs & Solutions

- A 'Who Handles This?' tool
    - Plain-language intake where the output tells you which entity has authority (county, VDOT, city, HOA, park, state, federal, etc), their real contact channel, and what info to include.
- A 'which government is this' jurisdiction lookup
    - I am in Fairfax county, the town of Vienna, or the City of Fairfax - who is my Board of Supervisors district rep, my school board rep, my state delegate?
- A public response-time tool
    - Residents can report a log of when they contacted a specific department and how long it took for them to respond
    - Resident-run tracker could surface disparities publicly which could be a useful tool for fairfax residents

Next Steps from **Meeting on Thursday September 10th at 8:30pm**

- Google Meet: https://meet.google.com/uig-erey-nnm
- Mannan will reach out about the next timing
- We will each take a potential problem area, do a bit of research and reach out to potential stakeholders to better understand the problem
    - Officials don't hear from their constituents because they don't have a good system for getting information?
        - Which do you hear frmo frequently and which do you not?
    - Homeowners don't know how to access government information or don't trust people, so they give up on projects
    - Immigrants don't feel like their needs matter, so they stay silent and never reach out for help.
    - I don't know enough about my local government to what is needed or how to improve it
    - Next time we get together, we'll share what we found and select a focus.

Over the weekend, we each look at a sub problem and talk to people. Come back after the weekend and decide the problem we want to focus on

- Put together a clear problem statement
- How will this tool help our target audience? What need do they have that we are trying to solve? How can this AI tool solve that need?
- What do we each want to get out of this?
    - Maggie: here for AI learning and people

    - Mannan: comfortable with AI, starting work on Monday, happy to share what I know, want to solve a problem even if it is tiny- I finished it, even if it is small, collaborating better with people.
    - Julie: cool process, hoping to learn about upskilling process and ready to help others, more motivate to help others succeed- interested in engaging in civics more myself, working with consensus is a strength
- Our Roles
    - Mannan- AI expert
    - Julie- background research, report writing and summarizing things
    - Maggie- wants to code
- What does success look like?
- Work style?
- Mannan will send a poll- Mannan is going to send a calendly link thing
    - Monday
    - Wednesday
    - Thursday earlier in the day potentially?

Week of 8/31

Background Notes

People Powered - series on digital participation platforms
https://www.peoplepowered.org/news-content/digital-participation-case-study-bogota

This is part of a series of stories on digital participation platforms produced with support from the Friedrich Naumann Foundation's Global Innovation Hub, Taipei. To read others in the series, see these case studies from Germany and Northern Ireland.

Chatico - aims to "build a citizen-centered digital ecosystem, where digital tools not only inform, but also solve problems, listen to people, and transform public interaction with the State." allow residents to

- access information about public services
- participate in community campaigns
- stay informed about policies and citywide initiatives

Goal - user-friendliness?? - easily accessible for seniors, youth, people with disabilities, and residents with low digital literacy.

Data? - participation increased (esp. teen/youth)

Digital participation platforms https://www.peoplepowered.org/digital-guide-home

Energy Bill AI tool Project Plan

RE: Developing tool that efficiently provides an individual or trusted advisor the information and contacts they need to address issues with electricity (& water?) in Fairfax County (may narrow to specific neighborhoods if easier to develop for) - issues such as increase in rates, help with bills, etc.

Problem Statement

Fairfax County residents are facing a worsening utility affordability crisis, and the support systems meant to help them can be fragmented that can be challenging to navigate and even know where to get started.

Proposed Solution

An AI conversational tool (potentially accessible via WhatsApp), that lets residents ask plain-language questions about their electric bill and get accurate, personalized routing to the right program, application, or human contact. This tool will help residents know what programs and options are available to them as they continue to face increasing utility costs.

Potential Resident Questions

1. Rate & Bill Increase:
    a. Why did my bill go up? (base rate increase, fuel surcharge, seasonal usage, data center demand, etc.)
    b. The rates for electricity have increased recently, making it hard to make ends meet. What can I do?
    c. Utility usage and associated bill seem high (compared to prior housing/neighbors/other). Is there a leak? Poor energy efficiency? What can I do? (if own? If rent?)
    d. I cannot pay my electric bill (utility bill). What can I do?
        i. Power company rate increase
        ii. Loss of income
        iii. Single bill surprisingly large
    e. What is this charge on my bill? (rate riders, adjustment clauses, fees, etc.)
    f. My electric bill has gone up over the past few months, will my bill keep increasing?
2. Disconnection Notice:
    a. I got a disconnection notice, what do I do right now?
    b. Can i get on a payment plan for my electric bill?
    c. I have a medical condition that requires electricity, what can i do to stop my electricity from being cut off?
3. Assistance Programs:
    a. Are there any assistance programs that I qualify for?
    b. Are there state or federal assistance programs I can apply for?

    c. What is the Percentage of Income Payment Program and how do I apply?
    d. What is the LIHEAP Assistance program and how do I apply?
    e. What is the EnergyShare program?
4. Usage & Efficiency
    a. Why is my usage so high?
    b. How can I reduce my electricity use in my home?
    c. Are there rebates available for efficiency upgrades in my area?
    d. A company stopped by our house and offered to buy solar panels for the house and said we would benefit from reduced electric bills. Should we do it?
5. Logistics
    - How do I set up electricity/water in a new house or apartment? Transfer account to me?
    - We have lost power (or water quality) in our house. (or apartment). What should I do?

Answer Resources

Understand my bill	https://www.dominionenergy.com/yourbill
Why is my bill high	https://www.dominionenergy.com/virginia/save-energy/why-is-my-bill-high https://www.fairfaxtimes.com/articles/fairfax-residents-utility-bills-set-to-rise-in-2026/article_7875a665-c056-4396-aca8-c65cfdbdb06c.html
Rate increases/ riders	https://www.dominionenergy.com/virginia/rates-and-tariffs
Disconnection rules	https://law.lis.virginia.gov/admincode/title20/agency5/chapter330/section40/
Percentage of Income Payment Program (PIPP)	https://www.dss.virginia.gov/relief/pipp/
EnergyShare (Dominion Energy)	https://www.dominionenergy.com/energyshare-va?print=true
Low Income Energy Assistance Program (LIEAP)	https://www.liheap.org/
Bill disputes/ complaints	https://www.scc.virginia.gov/consumers/public-utility/utility-complaints/
Scam verification	Dominion: Protect yourself of scams/ Report a scammer

Report Outage	Dominion Energy: 1-866-366-4357 / Report Form / View Outage Map NOVEC: 1-703-335-0500 / Outage Center
Energy Efficiency	https://energy.virginia.gov/connect/energy-efficiency https://www.nbcwashington.com/news/consumer/how-to-lower-energy-bills-as-summer-approaches/3896488/
Solar panel program	https://www.fairfaxcounty.gov/environment-energy-coordination/going-solar https://www.fairfaxcounty.gov/environment-energy-coordination/two-programs-help-residents-go-solar https://switchtogether.com/en/solar/fairfaxcounty/home
Data centers	https://www.pcrehomes.com/blog/data-centers-fairfax-utility-bills/ https://annandaletoday.com/massive-energy-use-by-data-centers-could-lead-to-higher-electric-bills/ https://www.brookings.edu/articles/confronting-and-addressing-rising-energy-bills-linked-to-data-centers/
Community support	Solar United Neighbors (nonprofit)

Goals

1. Content stays accurate as rates, thresholds, and deadlines change
2. can identify which assistance program(s) they may qualify for
3. Urgent cases (disconnection noises) are triggered and routed to an organization or government office where they can speak with someone about their issue
4. The tool builds trust with vulnerable populations and makes it easier for them to navigate a complex system and leaves them with a better understanding of their options

Decision Trees

- Need to define questions and decision trees to answer questions
    - The rates for electricity have increased making it hard to make ends meet, what can I do?
        -
        - What assistance programs do I qualify for?
        - Do I qualify for the Percentage of Income Payment Program?
            - What is the Percentage of Income Payment Program?
                - Pay your reduced bill in full and on time each month
                - Each month, 1/12 of your old balance is forgiven
                - After 12 months of on-time payments, your past-due balance is gone
            - Do I qualify for the Percentage of Income Payment Program?
                - Are you a Dominion Energy or APCo/AEP customer?
                - What is your household income?
                - Do you have an active electrical account?
                - Do you have proof of income for the past 30 days?
                - Do you have a current electric bill?
                - Do you have SSN for all members of your household?
            - How do i stay enrolled in the program?
                - Re-verify your income each year
                - Report changes in income or household size
                - Stay current on monthly payments
                - Missing payments, making partial payments or failing to re-verify may cause removal from the PIPP
            - How do I apply for the PIPP
                - Option 1: Apply online through CommonHelp
                - Option 2: Submit a paper application to your Local Department of Social Services
            - What documents do i need to apply for the PIPP?
                - Proof of income for the last 30 days for all adults (18+) in the household
                - Current electric bill
                - SSN for all household members
        - Do i qualify for Dominion Energy's EnergyShare program?
            - What is EnergyShare?
                - Energy assistance for people who are having problem paying their energy bills.
                - Available year-round, regardless of income.
                - Program can also provide free home energy upgrades to help you use less energy
            - Do i qualify for EnergyShare?
                - You must live in Dominion Energy's service area
                - Must have received a disconnection notice

    - Need your service reconnected
    - Need help keeping your payment plan
    - Have received a budget billing removal notice
    - If you're 60 years of age or older, you may qualify for help more often
    - Military veterans and people with disabilities may qualify for an extra $500
        - To qualify you must be enrolled in an approved voucher program through one of the following organizations
            - Virginia Department of Veterans Services
            - Virginia Department of Aging and Rehabilitative Services' Center for Independent Living
- How does EnergyShare work?
    - Local agencies look at applications and decide who is eligible
    - If approved, the payment is sent directly to your energy company
- Is there a deadline to apply for EnergyShare
    - Help with Heating: October 1st - May 31st, Benefit Amount: up to $6000
    - Help with Cooling: June 1 - Sep. 30, Benefit Amount: up to $3000
- How do i apply for EnergyShare
    - You can find your local EnergyShare agency by calling 2-1-1 or visiting 211virginia.org
- What are EnergyShare's Free Home Energy Upgrades?
    - You may be able to get a free home energy assessment
    - A contractor will visit your home and recommend weatherization tips and ways to help you use less energy and lower your energy costs
- What energy upgrades are available through EnergyShare?
    - Upgrades may include LED light bulbs, low-flow showerheads and faucet aerators, attic/floor insulation, heat pump or air conditioner tune-ups, air and duct sealing, hot water take and pipe wrap insulation
- Do i qualify for EnergyShare upgrades?
    - Must be a Dominion Energy customer
    - Must have received bill payment help
- How do i apply for EnergyShare home upgrades?
    - Call 888-366-8280 and select the Income and Age Qualifying option

Research Findings

Research

RE: Developing tool that efficiently provides an individual or trusted advisor the information and contacts they need to address issues with electricity (& water?) in Fairfax County (may narrow to specific neighborhood if easier to develop for) - issues such as increase in rates, help with bills, etc.

Potential Resident Questions

1. Rate & Bill Increase:
    a. Why did my bill go up? (base rate increase, fuel surcharge, seasonal usage, data center demand, etc.)
    b. The rates for electricity have increased recently, making it hard to make ends meet. What can I do?
    c. Utility usage and associated bill seem high (compared to prior housing/neighbors/other). Is there a leak? Poor energy efficiency? What can I do? (if own? If rent?)
    d. I cannot pay my electric bill (utility bill). What can I do?
        i. Power company rate increase
        ii. Loss of income
        iii. Single bill surprisingly large
    e. What is this charge on my bill? (rate riders, adjustment clauses, fees, etc.)
    f. My electric bill has gone up over the past few months, will my bill keep increasing?
2. Disconnection Notice:
    a. I got a disconnection notice, what do I do right now?
    b. Can i get on a payment plan for my electric bill?
    c. I have a medical condition that requires electricity, what can i do to stop my electricity from being cut off?
3. Assistance Programs:
    a. Are there any assistance programs that I qualify for?
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    d. What is the LIHEAP Assistance program and how do I apply?
4. Usage & Efficiency
    a. Why is my usage so high?
    b. How can I reduce my electricity use in my home?
    c. Are there rebates available for efficiency upgrades in my area?
    d. A company stopped by our house and offered to buy solar panels for the house and said we would benefit from reduced electric bills. Should we do it?
5. Logistics

- How do I set up electricity/water in a new house or apartment? Transfer account to me?
- We have lost power (or water quality) in our house. (or apartment). What should I do?
- My landlord hasn't turned on the heat and its 50 degrees outside, what can I do?

1. Officials don't get a representative sample of their constituents because they don't have a good system for getting information

- Authors assessed all named speakers in planning and zoning board meeting minutes, over 97 massachusets municipalities. Whoever shows up is typically older males, long time residents, and more likely to be a home owner. Those demographics do not represent the whole population evenly. https://maxwellpalmer.com/docs/articles/Einstein_Glick_Palmer_Participation.pdf
- 115 mayors from 37 states. 25% of them agreed public meetings attract a representative set of views, 68% disagree. 44% said public meetings can affect the the public housing built, reducing it, and when asked to recall a project not built that they also thought was feasible and beneficial, 25% of them said public opposition was the decisive factor. https://www.bu.edu/ioc/2026/03/31/2025-menino-survey-of-mayors-unlocking-housing-supply/
- Chiefs of staff and legislative directors in 91 congressional offices estimated their constituents' views on five policies, and staff from both parties guessed too conservative, with the largest errors among those who rely most heavily on business and conservative interest groups for policy information. https://www.cambridge.org/core/journals/american-political-science-review/article/abs/legislative-staff-and-representation-in-congress/D7735FCF39B843B9F3269FD39362FD66
- Surveys of 3,765 state legislative politicians in 2012 and 2014 found both parties overestimated constituent support for conservative positions by roughly 11 to 22 points, and a follow-up showed running campaigns and winning elections did not correct the error. https://www.cambridge.org/core/journals/american-political-science-review/article/abs/bias-in-perceptions-of-public-opinion-among-political-elites/2EF080E04D3AAE6AC1C894F52642E706

Some of the most interesting points include - they do want to hear from all residents, their small staff makes efforts to attend community events to share info on how to engage with office, often focus on school events such as back to school nights. (On schools, they note that individual schools have immigration liaisons in certain neighborhoods). They acknowledge that who they hear from is a skewed self-selected group - those that choose to walk in or call in or attend public meetings (the county holds many meetings as changes are proposed). They get a

broader sample of input on initiatives where feedback is sought on the county engagement portal. They do not collect demographic info on inquiries but andnecdotally (sp?) they hear more from older people and younger adults and some Immigrant/ethnic/communities of color are under-represented. (Except in one case of county-supported low-income housing). The most popular requests regard public transportation (e.g., street lights) and neighborhood fixes (e.g., sidewalks). They have noticed in the current administration and attention on ICE reduced participation in community events (e.g., National Night Out) and drop in public school enrollment.

2. Homeowners don't know how to access government information or don't trust people, so they give up on projects

3. Immigrants don't feel like their needs matter or comfortable enough to ask, so they stay silent and never reach out for help.
    a. Latino population (small sample size about 10- Guatemalan, Salvadoran, Honduran)
        i. fear, fear, fear, fear (for myself, for family members etc)
        ii. Anything government related is uncomfortable
        iii. Things through trusted organizations (meals through school) are different
        iv. School social workers are connectors
        v. Other immigrant families within apartment complex or at work are connectors
            1. Needs: Food, job, housing, daycare

4. I don't know enough about my local government to what is needed or how to improve it
    a. Upper-middle class, university educated people (small sample size of 12)-
        i. confirmed don't know what I don't know
        ii. Not seeking information out or going to websites- primary interaction was through the permitting process
        iii. Clicking on things that come to them in instagram
        iv. Time was also a pattern amongst those with young children, not a factor in 55+ group
    b.

National research on community's connectivity to their local government

- The National Civic League survey found that while many Americans felt left out of local decision-making and disconnected from their neighbors they remained eager for better ways to participate.
    - Less than 9% of people overall say they receive public information on time, with nearly half of urban residents reporting that information is at least "sometimes timely".
    - However more than a third of suburban residents said that information usually arrives late and reported the highest share of "too late" responses.
    - When it comes to taking part in local decision-making, nearly half cited time as the biggest barrier.
- ACCESS NYC: Mobile-friendly screener that matches users eligibility across 80 benefit programs, available in 11 languages, with human-translated program guides covering how to apply, what documents you need, and application channels.
- Southeast Iowa Resource Finder (SIRF): Electronic tool designed to streamline access to local service providers and resource the learning cost for individuals seeking assistance.
    - Minimizes complicated steps by helping users more quickly find the correct programs and avoid wasting time applying for the services they don't qualify for or missing necessary documentation

Fairfax County's own research points to residents needing better connection to resources as a growing challenge

- Community Health Improvement Plan (CHIP) - The county found that despite Fairfax being a resource-rich community, navigating complex systems and processes required to access assistance presents significant challenges, becoming a barrier for many.
    - Community members reported difficulty keeping track of the vast and fragmented health information available
- Fairfax County deployed 'Ask Fairfax' AI Chatbot last month
    - Answers questions in a conversational format, pulling answers from the county website
    - Multilingual
- Fairfax County doesn't appear to have a true 311
    - Contact page directs people to a general information line, with more specific questions getting routed to a list of separate numbers

Immigrant Community's Access to Government

- In 2022 VA released a 'Barriers to Integration of Virginia's Immigrants' report - there's a section about Overcoming a Trust Deficit and Uncertain Legal Status as a Barrier to Civic Integration
    - Lack of trust means that information needs to move outside government press releases and leverage the power of one-to-one interactions through social media and WhatApp
    - Uncertainty and fear mean that many immigrants avoid social and community events, leaving their voices unheard.
- In 2021 Fairfax announced they would be creating an Immigrant Community Liaison, a new position that would work to build bridges with local immigrant communities
    - Position was supposed to work with community, stakeholder groups, nonprofits, and interfaith organization to create strong networks that facilitate coordination and the connection of Fairfax County's immigrant community to the information, resources, and services that will support their success

Potential Needs & Solutions

- A 'Who Handles This?' tool
    - Plain-language intake where the output tells you which entity has authority (county, VDOT, city, HOA, park, state, federal, etc), their real contact channel, and what info to include.
- A 'which government is this' jurisdiction lookup
    - I am in Fairfax county, the town of Vienna, or the City of Fairfax - who is my Board of Supervisors district rep, my school board rep, my state delegate?
- A public response-time tool
    - Residents can report a log of when they contacted a specific department and how long it took for them to respond
    - Resident-run tracker could surface disparities publicly which could be a useful tool for fairfax residents

Problem: Awareness/ Government Not for Me

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1. "Symptom-to-System" Conversational AI Tools

Instead of asking citizens *"Which department do you need to reach?"* or *"What service are you looking for?"*, tools focus purely on everyday human symptoms.

- **How it Works:** An AI interface (via WhatsApp, voice notes, or SMS) prompts users to describe what is stressing them out in plain language—without using any civic vocabulary.
- **The Interaction:**
    - **User:** *"My boss cut my hours because I asked why my paycheck was short, and now I can't pay my electric bill."*
    - **AI Re-frame:** *"This is not just a personal disagreement with your employer. Under labor laws, your boss cannot legally punish you for asking about missing pay (Retaliation). Also, there is an emergency utility grant program specifically designed to stop electric shutoffs while wage claims are investigated."*
- **The Shift:** It bridges the gap between *"I'm having a bad week"* and *"My rights are being infringed, and there is a public agency built to intervene."*

2. Integrated "Civic Screening" at Life Touchpoints

People rarely visit government websites to browse services, but they *do* interact with healthcare providers, clinics, and community centers when in crisis.

- **How it Works:** Similar to how medical clinics screen for social determinants of health (e.g., food insecurity, domestic safety), frontline workers use simple 3-question intake screeners:
    - *"Is anything in your home making your family sick (like leaks, fumes, or mold)?"*
    - *"Do you feel safe walking to your bus stop or school at night?"*
    - *"Has an employer ever withheld money you earned?"*
- **The Shift:** If the person checks "yes," the intake system automatically flags that a public agency has jurisdiction, connects them with a community navigator, and frames the issue as a legal right rather than a private burden.

3: The "Sticky Note / Laundry Mat" Physical Grid (Analog & Visual)

- **How It Works:** Set up a large, color-coded poster board in high-foot-traffic community spaces (laundromats, food pantries, barber shops, transit hubs).
- **The Exercise:** People write their daily frustrations on sticky notes (e.g., *"bus is always late," "landlord won't fix heater," "reckless drivers on my block"*). A facilitator or simple color key guides them to place their note under one of three headings:
    1. **Private Life** (My responsibility)
    2. **Landlord / Private Business** (Contract responsibility)
    3. **Government Obligation** (Public right & agency duty)



Why It Works: It requires zero literacy in legal or civic jargon and creates a visual "aha!" moment as people see the "Government Obligation" column fill up with issues they previously blamed on bad luck.

Option 2A: Self-Serve "Civic Drop-Boxes" & Wall Displays

- **How It Works:** Permanent, low-tech installations placed in waiting areas (laundromats, clinic lobbies, public library entrances, bus shelters).
- **The Mechanism:** A poster board displays a prompt like: *"What is broken on your block that you shouldn't have to fix yourself?"* Below it are printed cards with pre-labeled

checkboxes (e.g., [ ] Bad lighting [ ] Unsafe traffic [ ] Landlord issues) and a drop slot. Staff or CBO volunteers collect cards weekly.
- **Why It Works:** Requires zero smartphone technology or scheduled time; residents participate passively while waiting for laundry or a bus.

3b: Asynchronous Messaging & Voice Micro-Polls

- **How It Works:** QR codes and simple SMS numbers posted on flyers, receipts, or community bulletin boards (e.g., *"Text 'MYBLOCK' to 555-0192"*).
- **The Mechanism:** When a resident texts or scans, an automated messaging thread asks 3 simple, spaced-out questions over a week (e.g., *"Day 1: What's your biggest neighborhood frustration?"*). A automated bot categorizes their answer and responds with an instant breakdown of whether that issue falls under city, state, or private jurisdiction.
- **Why It Works:** Highly flexible—residents complete the interaction in 15-second bursts on WhatsApp or SMS whenever they have free time.

3c: Photo-Driven "Scavenger Map" Activity (Self-Guided)

- **How It Works:** A passive challenge distributed via school flyers, CBO newsletters, or local social media groups that residents complete on their own daily routines.
- **The Mechanism:** Residents take a photo of an everyday neighborhood problem (e.g., an overflowing trash bin, broken playground equipment, unlit crosswalk) while running errands. They upload it to a lightweight web portal or dedicated WhatsApp number. The tool automatically overlays the name and contact info of the responsible public agency onto the image and sends it back to them.
- **Why It Works:** Integrates seamlessly into daily commutes or dog walks without requiring dedicated meeting times or group logistics.

Variation 0B: Scenario-Based "Life Event" Hub (Category-Driven)

- **How it works:** A visual menu organized by real-life situations rather than city departments.
- **The Mechanism:** Instead of listing "Department of Transportation" or "Department of Consumer Affairs," the user selects broad life categories:
  - 🏠 *My Living Space* (Rent, repairs, property taxes, neighbors)
  - 💼 *Earning a Living* (Starting a business, street vending, worker rights)
  - 🚗 *Getting Around* (Parking, transit, street safety)
- **Outcome:** Clicking a category expands a simple diagnostic question (e.g., under *My Living Space*: *"Are you renting or owning?"* → *"Is the issue related to physical safety, legal paperwork, or costs?"*), guiding them straight to the relevant journey map.

Fear

Fear

Variation 2A: The "Privacy-Shielded" Anonymous Proxy (Focus: Trust & Security)

- **Mechanism:** A WhatsApp or Signal bot operated by an independent legal aid or immigrant-advocacy coalition (rather than a city-adjacent vendor).
- **How It Works:** The resident submits a localized grievance via text or voice note. The tool strips all metadata (IP addresses, phone numbers, location tags), translates the issue, and maps it to the precise municipal code violation. It then issues a proxy ticket on behalf of *"An Anonymous Resident of Ward 4"* to the relevant agency.
- **Why It Fixes the Issue:** Solves the fear of government retaliation or immigration enforcement tracking. It provides the resident with an internal tracking ID so they can check resolution status through the bot without ever exposing their identity to public agencies.

Variation 2B: Audio-First Voice-to-Text Assistants (Focus: Low-Literacy & Oral Cultures)

- **Mechanism:** Voice-based conversational AI integrated into WhatsApp, Telegram, or Zalo, configured specifically for languages with low written literacy rates or non-Latin alphabets.
- **How It Works:** Users hold down the microphone button and describe their issue in their native dialect (e.g., *"My landlord shut off the heat and won't return my calls"*). The bot uses speech-recognition models to parse the core problem, responds with a short, friendly **audio explanation** of which agency enforces heat standards, and outlines the exact steps to file an inquiry safely.
- **Why It Fixes the Issue:** Removes the barrier of written literacy and complex administrative form-filling, allowing users to communicate naturally through speech.

Variation 2C: Community Group-Sourced "Peer Verification" Bots (Focus: Crowdsourced Mutual Aid)

- **Mechanism:** An interactive bot integrated directly into existing group chats (like a local neighborhood WeChat group, Facebook Group, or WhatsApp Broadcast Channel).
- **How It Works:** When a member asks a common civic question in the group chat (e.g., *"Is the city allowed to inspect my basement apartment?"*), the

community-moderated bot responds in-line with a verified, multi-lingual summary of city policy, citing the specific municipal code and agency responsible for oversight.
- **Why It Fixes the Issue:** Integrates directly into existing peer networks. Instead of expecting an individual to seek out a municipal tool, the information meets them in the spaces where they are already seeking advice from neighbors.

Variation 2D: Visual "Tap-to-Identify" Interactive Flowcharts (Focus: Low-Tech & Language Agnostic)

- **Mechanism:** A web-based or messaging-native micro-app that relies entirely on visual icons, diagrams, and localized photos rather than long text options.
- **How It Works:** The user opens a link in WhatsApp and is presented with simple image tiles depicting common daily problems (e.g., a picture of a trash-filled alley, a broken heating unit, an unlit street, or a shorted paycheck). Tapping an image opens a 3-step visual sequence showing:
    1. The problem picture
    2. The logo/name of the official agency legally mandated to fix it
    3. A single button to send a pre-formatted, anonymous message to a local community advocate who will advocate on their behalf
- **Why It Fixes the Issue:** Bypasses text translation errors entirely, using visual storytelling to build rapid mental maps of government responsibilities.

Confusing and Intimidating

Confusing and Intimidating

1. One front door: “Tell us what you need”

Instead of asking residents to choose between agencies or programs, the system starts with the problem itself.

A person could access the same simple interface on their phone, at a kiosk/tablet, or with someone at a library, school, community center, clinic, food market, or other familiar location.

They might tap an image or say:

> “My landlord won’t fix the heat.”

AI could then identify the likely category, ask only the necessary follow-up questions, determine which organization is responsible, and translate the person's description into the terminology that the system expects.

The output isn't a page of resources. It is something like:

Here’s what we can do next → Report this to X.
What would you like? → Do it myself | Help me do it | Connect me with someone

The important design principle is that **the resident describes the problem; the technology figures out the bureaucracy.**

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2. Trusted places become navigation points

This takes advantage of where people already go rather than creating another unfamiliar government office.

You could create a network of **Help Here** locations—libraries, schools, recreation centers, clinics, nonprofits, faith/community organizations, etc.

A resident walks in and says:

> “I need help with this.”

The staff member doesn't have to become an expert in housing, employment, benefits, transportation, and immigration. They open the same AI navigator.

Resident + trusted person → AI navigator → appropriate system

AI could help the navigator ask the right questions, identify the responsible organization, generate a script or form, translate, and explain the next step.

That dramatically changes the scalability problem. Instead of training thousands of people to become expert case managers, you're training them to be **good entry points into a shared navigation system.**

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3. Warm handoffs: don't end with a phone number

This is where I think the concept gets substantially stronger.

Most resource directories effectively end with:

“You should contact this organization. Here's their number.”

Your system could continue the journey.

For example:

Problem: “My employer hasn't paid me.”

AI determines: This likely belongs with an employment/wage enforcement process.

Prepare: AI helps collect the five pieces of information likely to be needed.

Choose support:
📱 **I'll contact them**
🤝 **Help me contact them**
👤 **Connect me to someone**

If the person chooses help, a navigator at a participating physical location could help make the call, initiate an online request, schedule an appointment, or electronically transfer the information—with the resident's permission—to a participating service provider.

Then the system retains a simple record:

✓ You asked for help Tuesday
✓ Case #12345
⏳ They should respond within 5 days
→ No response? Here's your next step.

AI becomes particularly useful **between interactions**, because it can explain what happened and what to do next without requiring the resident to understand the underlying bureaucracy.

Tab 7